It must have been an amazing night for Paul Gascoigne. He was back at Lazio's home ground with England and he was the one celebrating. People back home had been wondering if he was past his best and here he'd turned in the kind of performance you'd never forget. The way Gazza played that night —his ability, his nerve and the passion—I still wonder if that wasn't what we were missing at France 98. I know Glenn Hoddle had his reasons for not including Paul in the squad, but I think we'd have been better with Gazza there. Even if it was just him coming off the bench for twenty minutes, Paul could bring something to the team nobody else could. He could change a game on his own. And I know we'd all have liked him to be around as part of the squad.

What made it worse was the way Paul and the others found out they weren't going to be in the final 22 for the tournament. It was a bit like a meat market: 'You're in. You're out.' It was the wrong way to go about doing it. We were in La Manga in southern Spain, 27 of us in all, to prepare for the World Cup together before the manager made his decision about the final squad. Everybody was nervous, thinking about who wouldn't be going to France. *It could be someone from my club, a mate. It could be me*. One afternoon, after training, we were given timed appointments at the hotel: five-minute slots to go in and see Glenn, to find out what was going to happen to us. Almost from the start, the schedule wasn't working. I remember, at one point, sitting on the floor in a corridor with five other lads while we waited our turn. It was a ridiculous way to treat the players.

When eventually it came to my turn, the meeting didn't last long. Looking back, it makes it seem even more unlikely that things turned out for me the way they did once the World Cup began. I walked into the room and Glenn's first words were:

'Well, David, it goes without saying that you're in the squad.'

And that was it. At least I didn't hold up the next appointment. I was in the 22; but what about everyone else? Rumors had been flying around all day, not surprising when everybody was just waiting to find out what would happen to them. There was a leak somewhere in the camp, too: stories kept on turning up in the papers that could only have come from inside the England set-up. People were saying there was going to be one big story coming out of all this, that one high-profile name would be left out of the squad. The suggestion seemed to be that it would be Gazza. But nobody knew for sure, neither the press nor the players.